

In older computers, sometimes the ROM was all there was. The ROM included a basic operating system that often included programming tools such as a BASIC interpreter so you could write your own programs and run them without having anything else installed! ROM files are basically the contents of these ROM chips put into a file, and those contents are copyrighted.

Some of the companies that created these systems are actually OK with their distribution as ROMs and their use in emulators. You can find these by searching for “MESS roms” in the search engine of your choice. Without this there isn’t much you can begin to do.

While MESS and MAME and both brilliant solutions for emulating a wide range of systems, they come up a little short when you just want to play a few of the old school Nintendo, SEGA or PlayStation games. That’s where we turn our attention next.

Console Emulation

If you’ve grown playing games on previous generations of consoles, getting to relive those experiences can be a wonderful experience. Unfortunately the hardware is not available anymore, and the rerelease of those games is unlikely unless there is hint of a huge profit margin.

Worry not, emulating old school consoles such as the NES (Nintendo Entertainment System) is quite easy these days. In fact you can even get emulators for Android phones and tablets that let you play those games on the go. The gap between the power of the original NES and computers of today is so large now that it is possible to emulate its games inside a browser! The JSNES project is a NES emulator written in JavaScript, so it



The JSNES browser-based NES emulator running Super Mario Bros.

can play NES games right inside a browser window.

Alternatively, Emulators can put all that extra horsepower to good use and make upscale old graphics, add anti-aliasing, and even make it possible to save game state for older consoles that never had this feature.

Before we dive into the different systems and their emulators, let’s first tackle the issue of ROMs as they pertain to console games. Like we